

Can and ABLED

A university for the physically challenged gives hope to those less fortunate and shows the way forward

By Subhash Mishra

Namita Gupta, 19, from Varanasi has been suffering from cerebral palsy, a disease in which the mind and the body do not work in sync. She was a top student and her parents had wanted to send her for higher studies but failed to do so because of the hostile atmosphere at regular universities and colleges. Though Gupta comprehends well, she speaks slowly with multiple breaks and can neither write nor walk properly. But Gupta has hope now, thanks to the Dr Shakuntala Mishra Rehabilitation University (DSMRU) in Lucknow, an initiative of Chief Minister Mayawati and BSP General Secretary Satish Chandra Mishra. She is now pursuing a BEd in hearing impairment and will acquire a job soon. With the help of two assistants provided by the university, Gupta can now express herself in writing and go wherever she pleases. Her mother has also been lodged with her on the campus. For thousands like Gupta, the DSMRU is fulfilling dreams every day.

The Central Government had been promising such a university for the last 15 years. As awareness about the needs of the physically challenged grew and social attitudes to them changed, it was realised that there simply aren't enough opportunities for them, especially in higher education.

The chief minister was

so committed to the cause that she did not lose time in sanctioning over Rs 398 crore for the university. Last September she inaugurated the university in the name of Satish's mother, the late Shakuntala Mishra, who worked with the physically challenged for 20 years. Satish and Shakuntala have fought long battles in the courts trying to ensure reservation for the physically challenged in educational institutions and have been instrumental in the construction of ramps on footpaths and in providing them with government jobs. Satish is now personally monitoring the development of this university spread over 130 acres.

Till now, the physically challenged were left stranded when it came to deciding where to study and where to get financial support from. "As a result, they dropped the idea of pursuing higher studies all together," says Vice-Chancellor R.P. Singh, DSMRU. Despite the fact that Uttar Pradesh alone has more than 35 lakh physically challenged persons, only a small percentage of them have access to

higher education due to social and economic reasons. "Many a time the government is not even able to fulfil the 3 per cent mandatory reservation in its services," says the Principal Secretary (Disabled Welfare), Shailesh Krishna, who is also the principal secretary to the chief minister. He said this is where the DSMRU is going to provide the best trained manpower.

The DSMRU is providing special education in BEd in hearing impairment, mental retardation, visual impairment and a diploma in education in these specialised courses. The annual admission fee starts at about Rs 15,000 and varies from course to course. Speaking to INDIA TODAY, Satish explained that all the rooms and

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70 per cent of the physically challenged live in rural India



“The literacy rate among the physically challenged is 42 per cent, but employment, especially at higher levels, is low, which shows a lack of higher education.”

SATISH CHANDRA MISHRA,
General Secretary, BSP